

Violence and Defiance of Authority in Mughal India: A Study of the Shoe Sellers' Riot of Shahjahanabad*

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Najaf Haider¹

Abstract

In March 1729 AD, the city of Shahjahanabad (Mughal Delhi) was brought to a standstill following a conflict between shoe sellers and state officials. The conflict led to a violent showdown during the Friday congregational prayer in the central mosque of the city (Jami Masjid). The shoe sellers' riot exposed fissures based on religion, class and politics and posed a challenge to the authority of the Mughal state during the twilight of the Empire. The article is a study of the riot and the riot narratives preserved in three unpublished contemporary works. Together with a discussion of the Ahmedabad riot of 1714 AD, the article examines the nature of conflicts involving civilian population in the cities of Mughal India in the early eighteenth century and the response of political and religious authorities. An important aspect of the incidents studied in the article is the role of religion in organizing group violence even when the cause of the conflict was not necessarily religious. Conversely, cross-community support arising from patronage, class and notions of pride and honour demonstrated that religion was one among many possible forms of identity in Mughal India.

Keywords

Shahjahanabad, festivals, shoe sellers, Jami Masjid, Mughal state, Raushan-ud-Daula Zafar Khan, Qamaruddin Khan

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¹ Centre for Historical Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, Delhi, India.

Corresponding author:

Najaf Haider, Centre for Historical Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, Delhi 110067, India.

E-mail: snajafhaider@gmail.com

The Mughal city of Shahjahanabad (Delhi), capital of the Empire, had two high streets, the longer one extending east–west from the Lahore Gate of the imperial palace to the Lahore Gate of the city (present-day Chandni Chowk) and the shorter street stretching north–south from the Akbarabad (Agra) Gate of the palace to the Akbarabad Gate of the city (present-day Daryaganj). Both streets were lined up with shops and warehouses, *sarais* for merchants, bathhouses (*hammam*) and mosques.¹ A noble and high official of the Mughal Emperor Muhammad Shah (1719–1748), Raushan-ud-Daula Zafar Khan, had built two small and elegant mosques, one on each street. Raushan-ud-Daula was devoted to a holy man from Panipat, his hometown, and had built a symbolic resting place for him, Takiya Shah Bhik, in the middle of Akbarabad Gate street.² From where it started, the palace end, the street had a public square called Chauk Sadullah Khan, named after a Mughal minister. During the day, the *chowk* bustled with activities of story-tellers, jesters and bards (*bad farosh*), astrologers and geomancers, *hakims* selling aphrodisiacs in colourful bags, cooked food and dry-fruits sellers. Preachers brought their own stool and set themselves up for public preaching. People, overwhelmed with emotions by their stories, gave them money cheerfully.³ It was in Chauk Sadullah Khan that an incident occurred in the night that precipitated the shoe sellers' riot. The article is a study of the riot based on three unpublished contemporary sources.⁴ The description of the riot in the sources is independent of each other. The core information about the event is present in all the three sources, and the difference lies in details and interpretations. The sources are introduced and commented upon after the description and analysis of the event. Towards the end, there is a short comparison between the shoe sellers' riot of Shahjahanabad and the Holi riot of Ahmedabad. The purpose of the article is to understand the nature of violence involving the civilian population in the cities of Mughal India in the early eighteenth century and the role of political and religious authorities in responding to it.

¹ Muhammad Salih Kanbu Lahori, *Amal i Salih*, ed. Ghulam Yazdani, vol. 3 (Calcutta, 1939), 48–9; Syed Ali Nadeem Rezavi, “‘The Mighty Defensive Fort.’ Red Fort of Delhi Under Shahjahan-Its Plan and Structures as Described by Muhammad Waris’, *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 71st Session 2010–2011, pp. 1112, 1118; Francois Bernier, *Travels in the Mogul Empire AD 1656–1668*, trans. Archibald Constable (2nd edn., revised, Vincent A. Smith, London, 1916), 245.

² Najaf Haider, ‘Shahjahanabad in the “Gentil Collection”’, Paper presented to the workshop ‘Visiting Dilli 6’, Janaki Devi Memorial College, University of Delhi, 26 October 2018. Also see Susan Gole, ‘Three Maps of Shahjahanabad’, *South Asian Studies* 4, no. 1 (1988): 13–27.

³ Dargah Quli Khan, *Muraqqa i Dehli*, ed. and trans. Khaliq Anjum (New Delhi, 1993, Persian text), 60–61.

⁴ Muhammad Bakhsh ‘Ashob’, *Tarikh i Shahadat Farrukhsiyar wa Julus i Muhammad Shah* (hereafter Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*), British Library, MS. Or. 1832, ff. 56a–64b; Muhammad Shafi ‘Warid’, *Mirat i Waridat*, British Library, MS Add. 6579, ff. 172b–175a (hereafter Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*); Khushhal Chand, *Tarikh i Muhammad Shahi urf Nadiruz Zamani*, Staatsbibliothek zu Berlin MS Or. Fol. 222, ff. 152a–153a (hereafter Khushhal Chand *Nadiruz Zamani*, Berlin MS). The account of the riot in William Irvine is a virtual translation of Ashob’s, *The Later Mughals*, vol. II (Delhi, reprint 1995), 257–63.

Flashpoint

The flashpoint for the shoe seller's riot was a festival celebration. In March 1729 AD, Muslims were celebrating the festival of lights and prayers for the dead (*shab i barat*) and Hindus were celebrating the festival of colours, Holi. On Wednesday night, 9 March 1729 (8 Shaban 1141 AH), Subkaran (var. Sobhkaran), an appraiser (*muqim*) in the department of imperial jewellery, was going home after finishing the business of the day at the office of the superintendent, Hafiz Khidmatgar Khan. Subkaran lived behind the jeweller's street and had to pass through Chauk Sadullah Khan, where Muslims and Hindus were celebrating by setting alight lamps and fireworks. The revellers included a group of shoe sellers (*paposh faroshan*), all Punjabi Muslims from Lahore, who had shops in Chauk Sadullah Khan. A 'world burning' squib (*mushak*) ignited by the shoe sellers hit the palanquin of Subkaran and burnt holes in his *darbar* dress. Subkaran's servants entered into an altercation with the shoe sellers, and soon abuses were hurled and blows exchanged. Even though the servants were armed, the shoe sellers were too many and pushed them back. They also seized the sword and shield of Subkaran's foot soldier (*piyada*). Subkaran reached home with a bruised ego and burnt clothes and ordered the soldier to find out the person responsible for the mischief and punish. When the soldier and the servants reached the spot, the crowd had already dispersed. They were desperate to take revenge and redeem themselves in the eyes of their master. A boy of the shoe-selling community was caught and beaten up mercilessly. An old man sleeping in the open heard the boy's cries for help and ran to his rescue. The boy survived but the old man got killed.⁵ According to one source, it was martyrdom at midnight.⁶

Mobilization

The old man killed by Subkaran's men was a respected member of the shoe-selling community. His real name was not known, but he was called Haji Hafiz because he had performed the seasonal pilgrimage (*haj*) and memorized the Quran (*hifz*). With a white beard and a black mark on his forehead, earned after years of prostration, Haji Hafiz had a reputation for piety and religiosity (*taqwa wa dindari*). His murder was doubly outrageous to the community. In the morning, the shocked shoe sellers assembled around the body and decided not to bury it until the murderers and the mastermind (*amir*) were punished. This form of protest was not uncommon in eighteenth-century Shahjahanabad.⁷ Soon, the crowd swelled to include people from outside the closed community of shoe sellers.

⁵ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, ff. 57a–b; Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 172b; Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, f. 152a.

⁶ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, ff. 57b.

⁷ Khafi Khan, *Muntakhab ul Lubab*, 2 vols., ed. Maulvi Kabiruddin Ahmad (Calcutta: Bibliotheca Indica, 1874), vol. II, 759.

Some of them were identified in an account simply as *jihal wa aubash*, an expression used by upper-class Muslims (even today) for the riff-raff. Others were Arabs, Iranians, Turks, Central Asians, Abyssinians, Ottoman Turks, Mughals and Hindustanis. Shahjahanabad was the cosmopolitan capital of the Empire that had attracted people from the Islamic world over the past two centuries. The large and diverse mob was united by the thread of religion and the determination to avenge the death of a fellow Muslim at the hands of the 'infidels'. The first report was made to the police chief (*kotwal*) and the judge (*qazi*), the pillars of law and order in the city. The job of the *kotwal* was to investigate and apprehend the culprit, and that of the *qazi* was to conduct trial and convict or acquit. In this case, however, the men responsible for the murder were neither caught nor tried.⁸ The crowd put the corpse on a cot and walked in a procession, crying faith-faith (*din din*) and looking for the murderers and the mastermind. They reached the house (*haveli*) of Subkaran and, not finding him, sat there with the body.

Subkaran was no easy prey for the mob. He was in state service and well connected, being the protégé of Raushan-ud-Daula Zafar Khan, the *bakhshi* (paymaster) of the Empire and the man of two mosques and half a hospice. The department of jewellery Subkaran worked in fell under the overall charge of the *khan i saman*, a high-ranking officer responsible for the imperial establishment. The *khan i saman*, Sher Afgan Khan, and Raushan-ud-Daula shared a strong bond. They were both from Panipat and related to each other by marriage (*samdhi*). Family and patronage were essential elements of the Mughal bureaucracy along with loyalty, first to the emperor, ideally, and then to each other. Factions were formed within the nobility for greater control over resources and offices based on family connections and patronage. Subkaran was patronized by the two powerful nobles and received protection from both. Before the mob reached his *haveli* with evil intentions, Subkaran took shelter in the house of Sher Afgan Khan. Once Sher Afgan Khan denied knowledge of Subkaran's whereabouts, the mob left the 'body of the martyr at the door of the murderer' (*lash i shahid bar darwaza i qatil*) and went to appeal to the emperor for justice.

Emperor Muhammad Shah, coming back to the palace from a garden in the suburbs with his mother Qudsiya Begam, was met on the way by the crowd of supplicant-protestors (*fariyadian*) who shouted *din din* and demanded justice. The emperor knew about the incident and the difficulties involved in handling it.⁹ Muhammad Shah had modelled his kingship on the high ideals of Emperors Akbar and Jahangir and even installed a chain with bells from the tower of the imperial palace to the bank of River Yamuna for oppressed people seeking justice.¹⁰ Unlike Akbar or Jahangir, Muhammad Shah's grip over the administration and the various factions of the nobility was not that firm. The crisis posed a dilemma to the

⁸ Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, Berlin MS, f. 152b.

⁹ *Ibid.*, f. 152b.

¹⁰ Najaf Haider, 'Justice, Love and the Creative Imagination in Mughal India,' in *Bollywood Islamicate Histories*, eds. Ira Bhaskar and Richard Allen (Delhi-Bristol: Orient Blackswan-Intellect Books, 2020, forthcoming).

emperor. On the one hand, there was a mob crying for justice and appealing to religion with the conviction that Muslims ought to be given preference over others. On the other hand, it was a matter of life and death for a mid-ranking state official (*mansabdar*) protected by powerful people. Muhammad Shah ordered his principal minister (*wazir*), Itimad-ud-Daula Qamaruddin Khan, to find the culprit wherever he was and put the matter to an end after due application of the law. The choice of the *wazir* suggested the importance attached to the matter that was beyond the jurisdiction of local officials. The *wazir* was an old hand and occupied the highest office in the administrative hierarchy. He was the one who could match Raushan-ud-Daula's strength. Qamaruddin Khan and Raushan-ud-Daula belonged to different factions of the nobility and patronized different people. Qamaruddin Khan and his father, who too had been *wazir* earlier, were patrons of the Mughal (Central Asian) component of bureaucracy and the army. Raushan-ud-Daula, also of Central Asian lineage, had Indians ('Hindustani') and Afghans as retainers and followers.¹¹ Qamaruddin Khan mobilized his resources quickly, but it was not possible for his men to lay their hands on Subkaran. Sher Afgan Khan's haveli was secured from assaults and raids militarily and politically.

Nothing happened on Thursday except for negotiations, and the crowd went home leaving the body of Haji Hafiz in front of Subkaran's house. The parties could not break the deadlock due to disagreement over the law of retaliation (*lex talionis*). In Mughal India, the law of retaliation (*qisas*) gave the family of the victim the right to demand the same punishment as the crime after trial and conviction. The family also had the right to pardon the perpetrator on acceptance of blood money.¹² The shoe sellers were invoking the first provision of the law, an eye for an eye, which meant death to the murderer, in this case Subkaran. Sher Afgan Khan was trying hard to persuade the shoe sellers to accept blood money (*khun baha*) as heirs of the murdered man (*warasa i maqtul*).¹³ Neither party was willing to give in. According to one source, Sher Afgan Khan did not hand over Subkaran to the shoe sellers owing to the notion of valour prevalent among the 'Indian-born', as well as his personal code of honour.¹⁴

Violence in the Mosque

On the eve of Friday, the shoe sellers decided to present the matter to their religious leaders (*arbab i shara*), notably the judge (*qazi*) and the juriconsult (*mufti*), in the Jami Masjid, located diagonally across the palace, before the Friday congregational prayer. The office of the *qazi* itself was not religious, but the person, usually

¹¹ Satish Chandra, *Parties and Politics at the Mughal Court 1707–1740*, 4th ed. (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2002), 280–83.

¹² *Waq'a i Ajmer wa Ranthmbore*, Asafia Library, Hyderabad (Telangana State Central Library), MS Tarikh 2242, f. 24b; *Surat Documents*, Bibliothèque Nationale de France, Paris, MS Supplement Persan 482, f. 10a. See Farhat Hasan, *State and Locality in Mughal India. Power Relations in Western India c. 1572–1730* (New Delhi: Cambridge, 2006), 66, 69–70.

¹³ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shahi*, f. 60a; Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 172b.

¹⁴ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shahi*, f. 58a.

a Saiyid proficient in Muslim law (*sharia*), carried religious authority. The shoe sellers planned to advance the religious offensive in the hallowed precincts of the mosque and amplify the appeal for retribution.

The Jami Masjid of Shahjahanabad, built in 1656 AD as part of Shah Jahan's grand plan to establish a new capital city in Delhi, was a huge open-air mosque that could accommodate 2,000–3,000 people.¹⁵ It was meant both as a royal and a public mosque, since Shah Jahan did not construct any mosque inside the palace. The Jami Masjid became a point of contact between the Mughal Emperor and his subjects, mostly the elites (*ashraf*) of the city. The Emperor would come to offer prayers on important occasions as part of his rituals of piety and popular sovereignty. Expecting big trouble (*bala-i azim*), Muhammad Shah was advised not to go for the Friday prayer.¹⁶

On Friday, 11 March 1729, the shoe sellers walked from place to place in the morning, talking to people and inviting them to the mosque for support. Between morning and afternoon, such a large crowd had gathered inside the prayer hall and the courtyard (*sahn*) that there was no place for regular worshippers. Muslims from various *muhallas* came out to protect the right faith and defeat the infidel.¹⁷ The shoe sellers received help from a group of artillery soldiers in the mosque who had come as no ordinary worshippers. The artillerymen, mostly Arabs, Abyssinians and Ottoman Turks and their descendants, once in state employment under various commanders, including the head of the royal artillery (*mir atish*), Haidar Quli Khan, had come to the mosque with weapons in their holsters (*saz o yaraq*). They formed a circle around the pulpit (*mimbar*) and the prayer niche (*mihrab*) by squeezing the worshippers ('no space was left even for the mandatory standing-up (*iqamat*) required in the prayer') and allowed the shoe sellers to reach the front row. In the conversation that took place between the shoe sellers and religious authorities, the *qazi* spoke eloquently and put on the matter a spin favourable to Subkaran. For the supporters of the shoe sellers, the *qazi* 'belittled the severity of a serious cause using fantasy and deception (*fusun wa fareb*)'.¹⁸ The shoe sellers were outraged and accused the *qazi*, *mufti* and people of religious authority of siding with the 'infidels'. Their first act of defiance was to prevent the delivery of the sermon (*khutba*). Stopping the sermon was akin to challenging religious and royal authorities, as the *khutba* preceded the prayer and had the name of the emperor. The *qazi* and his eldest son, who was supportive of his father's position, were beaten and kicked almost to the point of death. The *qazi*'s dress was torn and his beard pulled so hard that 'hardly a hair remained'. The *mufti* and the *khatib* were dragged on the floor from the pulpit and beaten so much that they almost fainted.¹⁹

¹⁵ Khan, *Muntakhab ul Lubab*, II, p. 759.

¹⁶ Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, Berlin MS, f. 152b. Also see Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, f. 63b.

¹⁷ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, f. 59a.

¹⁸ Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 173a.

¹⁹ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, f. 59a; Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 173a.

When the news of the disturbance in the Jami Masjid reached the emperor, he ordered Qamaruddin Khan, as well as Raushan-ud-Daula, to proceed to the mosque with their troops. The 'two pillars of the Empire' were ordered to discipline the mob so that the sermon and the prayer could go on without hindrance. Qamaruddin Khan was the first to enter the mosque with a small contingent of about 25 soldiers who took positions on the northern side. The rest of his men, mostly Mughals, stayed outside. The *wazir* pitched himself as the 'friend of the Muslims' and argued in favour of retaliation (*qisas*). Qamaruddin Khan's gesture of support for the 'martyred Haji Hafiz (*shahid i mazlum*) against the oppressor (*kafir i zalim*)' helped assuage the fury, and many in the mosque regretted insulting and assaulting the *qazi*. The support from the highest official of the empire emboldened the shoe sellers to press the demand for retaliatory justice, but the great commotion within the mosque seemed to have died down.²⁰

At that instant, Raushan-ud-Daula made a grand entry from the magnificent eastern gate, the main entrance to the mosque meant for the emperor. He was wearing his signature gold-crested turban (*turra i zarrin*), which had earned him the moniker *turrabaz*.²¹ Raushan-ud-Daula's contingent comprised Afghan soldiers from the suburbs of Delhi and the *doab* as well as Afghan chiefs (*ruasa*) from the regions further east, Shajhanapur, Shamsabad and Farrukhabad, marked as *afghanistan i hindustan*. Raushan-ud-Daula's Indian soldiers were from his bailiwick, the *qasbas* around Thanesar and Sirhind, north of Panipat, where his *jagirs* were located. The men were 'deeply loyal to their patron (*aqqa*) and waiting to execute his command'. In a short time, once he got the news of the presence of the *wazir* and the *bakhshi*, Sher Afgan Khan too came into the mosque from the southern side with his soldiers, all Indians 'extremely loyal to him'. Once Sher Afgan Khan's men positioned themselves opposite Qamaruddin Khan's, Raushan-ud-Daula ordered his Afghan soldiers to close the doors of the mosque and stand guard.²²

The shoe sellers were incensed at the sight of the supporters of Subkaran and reacted with cries of *din din*. 'They looked at them as enemies and obstacles in the way of what they wanted'. The second, and deadly, round of violence began when the shoe sellers, possibly at the behest of Qamaruddin Khan, attacked Raushan-ud-Daula and Sher Afgan Khan with shoes and stones and bricks (*sang o khisht*) collected from the courtyard. The shoes were carried inside the mosque under armpits and some came with iron heels and wooden soles (*nalain*). Soon, shoes and missiles were flying thick and fast 'like falcons bringing down herons from their nests'. The first to be hit by a shoe was 'the lion of ferocity and valour Izzatud Daula Sher Afgan Khan Bahadur Safdar Jang'. Another shoe landed on the head of the 'high and mighty Raushan-ud-Daula and toppled his turban (*dastar*). The turban fell on his feet while the shoe sat on his head'.²³ At least two narrators of

²⁰ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, ff. 59a–b.

²¹ Khan, *Muntakhabu'l Lubab*, II, p. 908; Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 173a.

²² Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, f. 60a.

²³ Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 173b; Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, ff. 60a–b.

the incident were tickled by the imagery of the grandees of the Mughal Empire getting beaten by shoes, an experience of abject humiliation in India. Qamaruddin Khan watched the spectacle (*tamasha*) from the proximity of the pulpit along with his allies (*rufaqā*). The artillerymen and a group of mercenary soldiers of Mughal descent from beyond the city walls (Mughalpura) threw a protective ring around the *wazir*.²⁴

Counterattack

The first to launch a counterattack were the Afghan soldiers of Raushan-ud-Daula, who advanced with swords and shields (*shamshir o sipar*) against Qamaruddin Khan, who they regarded as the real villain of the piece. The attack was defended by the artillerymen with their flintlock muskets (*banduq i chaqmaqi*), pistols and European handguns (*tamancha-i firangi*). The Mughal mercenaries joined too with conventional weapons. A musketeer of Abyssinian origin fired a shot from near the pulpit at Raushan-ud-Daula and Sher Afgan Khan, standing together and giving instructions to their soldiers. The two sides were engaged in a violent fight. The shoe sellers had no weapons but launched themselves in the fray. The Afghans were too many and about to overwhelm their adversaries when the soldiers of Qamaruddin Khan who were waiting outside to escort him back barged into the mosque on their horses with artillerymen of his own contingent. An elephant, the personal ride of the *wazir*, stomped up the stairs. The soldiers of Raushan-ud-Daula and Sher Afgan Khan began to lose ground, and there were many casualties from their side. Sher Afgan Khan received a wound on his right hand and lost his sword. The two quickly consulted each other and decided to retreat. The soldiers of Raushan-ud-Daula flanked him for a safe exit, but he was too large and corpulent to move swiftly. His soldiers had to carry him on their shoulders. The nobles took shelter in the haveli of Dil Diler Khan, elder brother of Sher Afgan Khan, located close to the southern gate of the mosque. The Mughal soldiers of Qamaruddin Khan overstepped their command and planned to burn down the haveli, but they were dissuaded by the *wazir*.²⁵ Many nobles and allies of Raushan-ud-Daula were left behind and had to find places to hide in the mosque. Some of them jumped out of the mosque from the surrounding arched colonnades (*aiwan*). One noble, Azam Khan Bahadur, jumped on the thatched roof of a shop below and fell on the floor. The shopkeeper, a potter (*kulal*), lamented the loss of the roof and his jars and bottles (*khum wa kuza*) kept for sale.²⁶ According to another version, less reliable and possibly based on local folklore, the potter took out his anger on Azam Khan and beat him with a bamboo stick so badly that the noble had swollen feet and difficulties sitting on his chair (*masnad*).²⁷

²⁴ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, ff. 60b–61a.

²⁵ *Ibid.*, ff. 62a–b.

²⁶ Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, Berlin MS, f. 153a.

²⁷ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, f. 63a.

The riot lasted for about 3 hours, between the two prayers, namely *zuhr* and *asr*.²⁸ Just before the late afternoon prayer (*asr*), Qamaruddin Khan ordered the mosque to be cleared of corpses and rioters and posted his men at the gates with strict instructions not to let anyone in. The *wazir* offered the *asr* prayer not in the hall but in the enclosure on the north-western corner of the mosque where the ‘holy relics of the Prophet Muhammad’ (*asar sharif*) were kept. He thanked God and the prophet for giving him victory and gave customary offerings to the servants of the shrine. The emperor, who got a full report from his spy, sent his turban (*dastar*) to the *wazir* and ordered his presence in the palace. The *wazir* left the mosque along with the eunuch who had brought the royal turban. The shoe sellers too left the mosque feeling triumphant.²⁹

Grave and a Mosque

At the end of the day, it might have been the case that in the face-off in the mosque Raushan-ud-Daula and Sher Afgan Khan had lost to Qamaruddin Khan and, ipso facto, to the shoe sellers. Still, Subkaran had not surrendered. The shoe sellers, and the mob accompanying them, got the haveli of Subkaran, located in Guzar Dariba to the southeast of Chauk Sadullah Khan, as compensation. The haveli was demolished and the body of Haji Hafiz was buried at the site. The construction material of Subkaran’s haveli was used to build a mosque with the grave inside it.³⁰ Muhammad Bakhsh Ashob, the author of *Julus i Muhammadshahi*, whose account has been used extensively, once prayed in the mosque: ‘I crossed the street and went into the mosque, performed ablution from the water of the well and prayed. At the grave of Haji Shahid, I offered a short prayer for the salvation of his soul’.³¹

The Riot Narratives

Of the three narratives of the riot, the most detailed and useful is of Muhammad Bakhsh Ashob, a soldier, poet and historian born in Shahjahanabad. Ashob was in the administration of Muhammad Shah and wrote a history of the emperor in 1782 AD. Ashob was 13 years old at the time of the incident but makes no reference to having any memory of it. Instead, in the preface of the description of the riot, Ashob mentions discovering a ‘non-partisan’ version of the event in an anonymous history of Muhammad Shah and copying it verbatim (*harf ba harf*).³²

²⁸ Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, Berlin MS, f. 153a.

²⁹ Ashob, *Julus i Muhammad Shah*, ff. 63a–64a.

³⁰ *Ibid.*, f. 64a.

³¹ *Ibid.*

³² *Ibid.*, f. 56a. According to C. A. Storey, the anonymous work exists in fragments of a fuller court history and known only by the generic name of *Sahifa i Iqbal*. *Persian Literature, a Bio-Bibliographical Survey*, vol. part 1 (London: Routledge, 1970), 609.

However, Ashob's own account is hardly impartial and biased towards Qamaruddin Khan, who was his employer for some time. Also, generally speaking, he favours Mughal nobles and soldiers and not Indians and Afghans. Within this, a distinction is made between elites and commoners, and between Muslims and Hindus. The shoe sellers and their unidentified Muslim supporters are all commoners and rabble-rousers fighting for a just cause. According to Ashob, on the face of it, the riot was a violent conflict between the people of the city and the high nobility of the Mughal Empire (*umara i uzzam*) resident in Shahjahanabad. However, in actual fact, it was an attempt to humiliate Islam and strengthen *kufi*. Raushan-ud-Daula's discomfiture is narrated with sarcasm and delight. Ashob's account is long also due to repetitions and the author's tendency to use more words than necessary.

The second narrative is also of a state employee, Muhammad Shafi 'Warid', who served Prince Azimush Shan, Aurangzeb's grandson and Farrukhsiyar's father. Warid gave up the job and took to writing under the patronage of a small *jagirdar*, Bairam Khan, and finished his history, *Mirat i Waridat*, or *Mirror of Events*, in 1734 AD. According to Warid, the riot was a case of justice denied and manifestation of a general malaise caused by a tyrannical regime. While Ashob defends the emperor, Warid is critical of him. According to him, people were getting killed every day and there was no justice for them.³³ Warid's sympathy lay with the dead shoe seller more so because the murderer was a Hindu protected by the 'fox-like' Sher Afgan Khan and 'chief of thieves', the *qazi* of Shahjahanabad. For Warid, Qamaruddin Khan was a hero who, with a deep understanding of the situation and without the use of force, brought peace. Warid regrets that blood was shed in the house of God and blames Raushan-ud-Daula for that.

The third narrative is of Khushhal Chand, who was a *munshi* (composer of letters and documents) in the office of the *diwan* of the *suba* of Shahjahanabad during the reign of Muhammad Shah. His father, Jiwan Ram, too had been a *munshi* in the office of the *khan i saman* during the reign of Jahandar Shah. Khushhal Chand wrote a general history of India with a focus on the reign of Muhammad Shah in 1742 AD. According to him, the riot was a strange combination of divine providence, inept administration and group violence. The killing of the shoe seller was a quirk of fate, whereas the reaction of the victim's supporters was disproportionate. There is a hint of suggestion that the shoe sellers and their supporters were violent from the beginning. This aspect of mobilization is obscured by Ashob and Warid. According to Khushhal Chand, the emperor knew about the troublemakers and the excesses they had committed, but he, in his best wisdom, kept quiet. Khushhal Chand bemoans the unfair accusation levelled against the emperor of going against Islam (lit. *din i muhammadi* or Muhammadanism). The person who was on the side of truth and justice was Raushan-ud-Daula, and he was the one reining in the rabble-rousers. Khushhal Chand condemns the violence in the mosque but defends Qamaruddin Khan against the accusation of foul play. He offers a unique perspective, and his version counters the sectarianism of Ashob and Warid, albeit in a guarded manner.

³³ Warid, *Mirat i Waridat*, f. 172b.

The incident narrated above has been called the shoe sellers' riot in modern histories.³⁴ To the extent that shoe sellers were at the heart of the tumult, the labelling of the event is plausible. It was a riot lasting three tempestuous hours in the Jami Masjid, where the use of weapons of different kinds by the conflicting parties caused deaths and injuries. The incident meant different things to different people in Shahjahanabad. Subkaran's viewpoint is difficult to extract from even a combined narrative, but others saw it as villainy or a calamity brought upon him by vanity. The men of Subkaran went out of the picture while the focus stayed on him. Had he not had powerful patrons and friends, Subkaran would have lost his life or liberty and not merely his *haveli*.

For the shoe sellers, it was a matter of avenging (*intiqam*) the murder of a leading member of their community who was innocent (*mazlum*) and gave his life for the right cause (*shahid*). Their protest was couched in religious terms for two reasons. First, the Muslim society was hierarchical and the shoe sellers were looked down upon by their religious brethren belonging to the higher social order. Yet, they could garner support from fellow Muslims of the lower social order living in Shahjahanabad in the name of religion because that was the only platform available to them to rest the idea of revenge upon. Second, the killer of Haji Hafiz was not identified and spotlighting Subkaran enabled them to dovetail religion and oppression. The use of religion for mobilization was successful, as it had been for the shoe sellers of Lahore earlier against Hindus and Sikhs.³⁵ Law, however, trumped religion insofar as the demand for retribution was not legally admissible. Haji Hafiz had no heir, and Subkaran was not the murderer. Although *qazis* in the Mughal Empire were generally corrupt and susceptible to political pressure, the *qazi* of Shahjahanabad had a point. This was also the reason for the resentment shown against religious authorities. The turning of Subkaran's *haveli* into a religious space alludes to the parochial nature of the shoe sellers' campaign but it also demonstrates their outrage against status groups.

No matter how vociferous and persistent the shoe sellers were, it would not have been possible for them to gain 'victory' without the open support of artillerymen and mercenaries and the tacit support of the *wazir*. The two groups that turned the tide in the mosque were not directly connected with *wazir* Qamaruddin Khan, but they were working for him. Moreover, there were always possibilities of dispute between military commanders or their detachments and paymasters (*bakhshi*) over recruitment, salaries and allowances.

³⁴ Irvine, *The Later Mughals*, II, pp. 257–63; Chandra, 282–83; Saiyid Athar Abbas Rizvi, *Shah Waliullah and His Times* (Canberra: Ma'rifat Publishing House, 1980), 200–202. William Irvine was the first to draw attention to the event and considered it to be a sign of political turbulence and the beginning of the decline of 'palace favourites' besieging the Emperor. Satish Chandra interpreted the riot as evidence of the fissure between Mughals and non-Mughals (Indians and Afghans) caused by the declining resources of the Empire. Athar Abbas Rizvi examined the riot in the context of sectarian conflicts in the eighteenth century and argued that new power groups were emerging and replacing the old ones.

³⁵ Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, Asafiya MS Tarikh Farsi 2143, f. 41.

Even though the nobles were not directly fighting each other, the riot was a show of strength in which neither of the two factions could claim full victory. Qamaruddin Khan had the power and mandate to get the murderers arrested and tried and even persuade the shoe sellers to convert retribution into compensation. However, he chose not to do any of this. People indeed propagated the view that Qamaruddin Khan sided with the shoe sellers due to his professional rivalry with Raushan-ud-Daula.³⁶ In the mosque, his posture was openly populist, with which he gained the trust of the troublemakers. Qamaruddin Khan and his soldiers did not participate in the violence that followed. Like a shrewd tactician, the *wazir* let others do the job. The impression that we get from our sources is that after the riot was over, ‘everyone’ seemed happy with Qamaruddin Khan: the shoe sellers, ‘people’ of Shahjahanabad and, of course, the emperor. It was seen as a setback to Raushan-ud-Daula and his faction.

The riot was a setback for the emperor, whose authority had been publicly challenged in two distinct ways. First, the Friday sermon in which the name of the emperor and his regal protocol were inscribed and disseminated was not allowed in the central mosque. Second, officials appointed by the state that represented the authority of the emperor in the religious sphere—the *qazi*, the *mufti* and the *khatib*—were humiliated and assaulted with impunity. Unlike his predecessors, Muhammad Shah was too weak to take on a powerful noble over a dead shoe seller in the name of imperial justice. The emperor’s best move was to throw another powerful noble in the arena and watch. The outcome was favourable and the emperor was relieved. The crowd was pacified and the political equilibrium was not disturbed.

The Ahmedabad Riot of 1714

Fifteen years before Shahjahanabad, a riot took place in Ahmedabad that lasted for three days. After the violence ended, a petition on behalf of the victims of the riot was entertained by Emperor Farrukhsiyar, resulting in a court case in Shahjahanabad and a verdict against the rioters.³⁷ There are interesting parallels between the two riots, and a comparison can give us insights into mob violence and defiance of authority in big cities. Festival as a precipitant is common in both the riots. In Ahmedabad, the riot involved the festival of Holi and the hurt and humiliation experienced by a Muslim passer-by who was dragged into the celebration. The counterpart of Subkaran in Ahmedabad was Hari Ram, commercial agent of a big banker (*sarraf*) and treasurer of a Mughal noble, Madan Gopal. The Muslims of Ahmedabad, led by the chief sermon reader, Muhammad Ali *waiz*, and leader of the Sunni Bohra mercantile community, Abdul Aziz *topiwala*, drummed up support for the community. The *qazi* of Ahmedabad refused to join

³⁶ Khushhal Chand, *Nadiruz Zamani*, Berlin MS, f. 152b.

³⁷ Najaf Haider, ‘A “Holi Riot” of 1714: Versions from Ahmedabad and Delhi,’ in *Living Together Separately: Cultural India in History and Politics*, eds. Mushirul Hasan and Asim Roy (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2005), 127–44.

them and became the first casualty of the riot. His house was burnt down by the mob. The use of religion for strength and legitimacy (*din, din, kufi; zulm...*) and rejection of religious authority went together. This was an indication of politicization of religion and sacred spaces, such as the mosque. Professional rivalry was evident between the leaders of the mercantile community. In the attacks on Vaishnavite banias and Jain merchants and bankers (all 'Hindus' in the sources), the chief target was the *nagarseth* and jeweller, Kapur Chand Bhansali, the rival of Abdul Aziz *topiwala* in the politics of trade.

The violence was planned in the Jami Masjid of Ahmedabad before the Friday prayer and executed after that. Unlike Shahjahanabad, the riot here caused heavy destruction. In the first phase, shops in the busy commercial streets up to Manek Chowk and Teen Darwaza were looted. In the second, the residential area of the commercial elites (Zaveriwad) was attacked but saved by Muslim matchlockmen hired by Kapur Chand Bhansali. The governor of Gujarat, Daud Khan Panni, away from Ahmedabad, sent his soldiers to restore order. Meanwhile, the civilian elite got together and called for peace. In the court case in Shahjahanabad, the report sent by the governor clinched the verdict. Muhammad Ali *waiz*, one of the main accused, created quite a stir with his sermons in the Jami Masjid of Shahjahanabad and rallied people to his cause. Eventually, Abdul Aziz *topiwala* and Muhammad Ali *waiz* and others were put in prison. They were released by the machinations of a court faction working against Daud Khan and his patron, one of the Saiyid brothers. Muhammad Ali *waiz* settled down in Shahjahanabad and almost caused a Sunni–Shia riot with his preaching.

There are three versions of the Ahmedabad riot, namely local, metropolitan and itinerant.³⁸ The first version, in a local history of Gujarat, is strong on the events in Ahmedabad but weak on what happened in Shahjahanabad. According to this version, Kapur Chand Bhansali won the case but the eloquence and piety of Muhammad Ali *waiz* compelled the emperor to reverse the verdict. The version fast forwarded the climax and skipped the stage of prison sentence. The second version, coming from Shahjahanabad, adds a serious note to the precipitant by bringing in cow slaughter and the killing of a Muslim youth during the celebration of the Prophet Muhammad's birth anniversary. Here two contentious events were collapsed with a time lapse. The Muslims were convicted because of the influence of Ratan Chand, the *diwan* of one of the Saiyid brothers. In the third version, written by a petty Mughal official of Surat who travelled to Shahjahanabad, Kapur Chand bribed the nobles and got the case against him dismissed. There was a grudging acceptance of the role of the Muslims in the violence in all the three accounts, but it was overshadowed by the crimes committed by the other party. In the local history of Gujarat, regional identity softened the intensity of religious hostility.

³⁸ Ali Muhammad Khan, *Mirat i Ahmadi*, 2 vols and *Supplement*, ed. Syed Nawab Ali (Baroda, 1927–1930), vol. I, pp. 405–7, 410–12; Khan, *Muntakhab ul Lubab*, vol. II, pp. 755–7; Itimad Ali Khan, *Miratu-l Haqiqi*, MS. Bodleian, Oxford, Fraser 124, ff. 170b–171a.

Conclusion

A study of the riots reveals that festival celebrations made members of diverse sections of the society susceptible to transgression. All such acts did not lead to conflict and violence and thus were not written about. Self-restraint, intermediation and fear of authority stopped anger from breaking out quickly or snowballing into open conflict. It did not happen in the incidents discussed here because of group strength and defiance of authority.

Group violence drew strength from a feeling of invulnerability based on numbers and resources. Religion was a resource, along with leadership, that provided legitimacy and numbers. The role of religion in Ahmedabad was stronger because of the presence of a preacher whose bigotry extended till Shahjahanabad. The public preachers of Chauk Sadullah Khan brought fun into religion, but the preacher of Ahmedabad was a sermon reader in the Jami Masjid whose career flourished after the riot.³⁹ The other leader, Abdul Aziz *topiwala*, was a cap seller with aspirations and business interests. The city of Ahmedabad was on the verge of a commercial crisis deepened by Maratha incursions, and it is possible the depression dictated the choices made by Abdul Aziz and Kapur Chand.⁴⁰ The leadership in Shahjahanabad was collective and in the hands of elders of the shoe-selling community. Their real resource, however, was a faction of the nobility, which explains the difference in the nature and scale of violence in the two cities. Finally, the fight in Ahmedabad was between groups of more or less equal status and strength whereas in Shahjahanabad the commoner-elite dichotomy was sharp and the higher religious rhetoric absent.

It can be argued that the riots exposed the declining strength of the Mughal state, and incidents like these were not possible in the high noon of the Empire. However, state officials still worked to avoid the violence or contain it when it became inevitable. They certainly refrained from implicating themselves into a dispute or an act of violence. The riots brought to the fore challenges of religious neutrality of the state during the twilight of the Empire. A long-standing strategy of the Mughal state was mediation accompanied by limited penal actions.⁴¹ In the eighteenth century, the approach of the state was still to punish the guilty, but it was yielding to pressure. The punishment meted out to the guilty in Shahjahanabad was private and mediated through the state. In Ahmedabad, the guilty were acquitted without serving their full prison sentence. The riots revealed the strains on Mughal society created by narrow sectarian identities. The same society exhibited features of cross-community support based on patronage, class, profession and ecumenical notions of pride and honour.

³⁹ Not all sermon readers were bigots. A *waiz* of Sufi orientation recited verses from the Hindwi love poem *Chandayan* in a Delhi mosque. The worshippers asked him the reason for an ostensibly odd choice, and he explained how the recitation was in tune with 'certain verses of the Quran'. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhabu't Tawarikh*, ed. Ahmad Ali, 3 vols., vol. 1, Aligarh, 2018, p. 250.

⁴⁰ Haider, 'A "Holi Riot" of 1714,' 138–39.

⁴¹ Hasan, *State and Locality in Mughal India*, 66.

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